

D484

Penetration Testing

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A consultant is asked verbally by an IT manager at a 500-person manufacturer to test the network next week. The manager is enthusiastic and has a strong security background. What must happen before any testing?

- A. Written authorization from someone with authority, plus agreed rules of engagement.
- B. Announce the test to every employee.
- C. Nothing more; the manager's background makes the verbal OK enough.
- D. Start with passive research, then get the paperwork.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which document sets testing windows, allowed techniques, and emergency contacts for an engagement?

- A. The rules of engagement.
- B. The statement of work.
- C. The non-disclosure agreement.
- D. The final report.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A company's web app runs on a major public cloud, and the client signs an authorization to test "all our systems." The app has 1 million users. What must the tester also confirm?

- A. That testing follows the cloud provider's policy and targets only what the client controls.
- B. Nothing; the client's signature covers everything the app runs on.
- C. Only the testing time window.
- D. That the user count is within test limits.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A bank wants to see what an outside attacker with no inside knowledge could learn and reach; its board meets quarterly. Which type of test fits?

- A. A vulnerability scan.
- B. White-box testing.
- C. Gray-box testing.
- D. Black-box testing.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Testers are given source code, network diagrams, and admin credentials. Which type of test is this?

- A. Passive reconnaissance.
- B. Gray-box testing.
- C. Black-box testing.
- D. White-box testing.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A test team has signed rules of engagement and finished information gathering on a retailer with 80 stores. What is the next phase?

- A. Planning and scoping.
- B. Exploitation.
- C. Vulnerability identification.
- D. Reporting.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A tester for a regional hospital, working under signed rules of engagement with a three-week window, wants to gather information without directly touching the hospital's systems. Which activity fits?

- A. Sending test phishing emails to staff.
- B. Reviewing public records such as DNS registrations and job postings.
- C. Scanning the hospital's external addresses for open services.
- D. Any activity, as long as it is done slowly.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Why is active reconnaissance more likely than passive reconnaissance to be noticed by the target?

- A.** It relies only on public sources.
- B.** It never touches the target.
- C.** It is slower.
- D.** It sends traffic to target systems, which can be logged and alerted on.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A credit union's compliance officer, who has served on two audit committees, asks for testing that confirms whether findings can actually be exploited and what the impact would be. Which fits?

- A.** A risk questionnaire.
- B.** An audit committee review.
- C.** A penetration test.
- D.** A vulnerability scan.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A scanner reports a critical flaw, but manual checking shows the service version is already patched. What is this finding?

- A.** A false negative.
- B.** A false positive.
- C.** Critical anyway, since scanners are always right.
- D.** A true positive.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

The final report goes to the CEO and board, who have limited technical background; the engagement produced 23 findings across four subnets. Which section matters most for them?

- A.** All 23 findings sorted by subnet.
- B.** An executive summary of business risk and prioritized recommendations.
- C.** The full raw scan output.
- D.** A list of tools and methods used.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

After a critical finding is patched on 40 servers, what closes the loop? The patch team works nights.

- A.** Close the ticket once the patch is deployed.
- B.** Run a full penetration test before closing any finding.
- C.** Rescan or retest to confirm the fix, then close the ticket.
- D.** Move on, since the night team already handled it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

A consultant is asked verbally by an IT manager ~~at a 500-person manufacturer~~ to test the network next week. ~~The manager is enthusiastic and has a strong security background.~~ What must happen before any testing?

Target word: precondition for testing **Decides:** Only a verbal request exists.

A	Correct	Protects the client and tester and defines what is allowed.
B	Confusion set	Not required, and can defeat the test's purpose.
C	Camouflage	Expertise does not replace written authorization.
D	Adjacent category	Work under the engagement should wait for authorization.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

Which document sets testing windows, allowed techniques, and emergency contacts for an engagement?

Target word: reverse: contents to document **Decides:** Operational limits of testing.

A	Correct	RoE governs how, when, and what may be tested.
B	Adjacent category	Covers deliverables and cost, not day-to-day limits.
C	Confusion set	Covers confidentiality only.
D	Inverted operation	Written at the end, not before testing.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A company's web app runs on a major public cloud, and the client signs an authorization to test "all our systems." ~~The app has 1 million users.~~ What must the tester also confirm?

Target word: scope limit in the cloud **Decides:** The client does not own the provider's infrastructure.

A	Correct	The client cannot authorize testing of the provider's systems.
B	Absolute language	Authority stops at what the client owns or controls.
C	Dropped element	Timing matters but skips the ownership question.
D	Camouflage	User count does not define scope.

4. Answer D Concept 3

A bank wants to see what an outside attacker with no inside knowledge could learn and reach; ~~its board meets quarterly.~~ Which type of test fits?

Target word: knowledge level **Decides:** No inside knowledge given.

A	Confusion set	A scan is a tool, not a knowledge level.
B	Inverted operation	Gives testers full inside knowledge.
C	Adjacent category	Gives partial knowledge.
D	Correct	Testers start with no internal information.

5. Answer D Concept 3 · transfer

Testers are given source code, network diagrams, and admin credentials. Which type of test is this?

Target word: reverse: inputs to type **Decides:** Full information provided.

A	Confusion set	A phase activity, not a knowledge level.
B	Adjacent category	Only partial information.
C	Inverted operation	No information would be given.
D	Correct	Full knowledge and access.

6. Answer C Concept 4

A test team has signed rules of engagement and finished information gathering ~~on a retailer with 80 stores.~~ What is the next phase?

Target word: next phase **Decides:** Recon is done.

A	Inverted operation	Already done when the RoE was signed.
B	Dropped element	Skips identifying what to test.
C	Correct	Findings from recon are analyzed for weaknesses next.
D	Adjacent category	Comes last.

7. Answer B Concept 5

A tester for a regional hospital, ~~working under signed rules of engagement with a three-week window,~~ wants to gather information without directly touching the hospital's systems. Which activity fits?

Target word: passive recon **Decides:** No interaction with target systems.

A	Adjacent category	Social engineering interacts with people at the target.
B	Correct	Public sources involve no contact with the target.
C	Confusion set	Scanning touches the target, so it is active.
D	Absolute language	Speed does not change whether the target is contacted.

8. Answer D Concept 5 · transfer

Why is active reconnaissance more likely than passive reconnaissance to be noticed by the target?

Target word: reverse: property to cause **Decides:** Active recon contacts target systems.

A	Inverted operation	That describes passive recon.
B	Confusion set	That is also passive recon.
C	Adjacent category	Speed is not why it is detectable.
D	Correct	Direct interaction leaves traces.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A credit union's compliance officer, ~~who has served on two audit committees,~~ asks for testing that confirms whether findings can actually be exploited and what the impact would be. Which fits?

Target word: scan or pen test **Decides:** Needs confirmation of exploitability and impact.

A	Adjacent category	Collects self-reported answers.
B	Camouflage	Follows the officer's background, not the need.
C	Correct	It validates exploitability and impact.
D	Confusion set	Lists possible issues without confirming them.

10. Answer B Concept 6 · transfer

A scanner reports a critical flaw, but manual checking shows the service version is already patched. What is this finding?

Target word: classify the finding **Decides:** Reported, but not really present.

A	Inverted operation	That is a real issue the tool missed.
B	Correct	The tool flagged an issue that is not there.
C	Absolute language	Scanner results need verification.
D	Confusion set	Verification showed it is not real.

11. Answer B Concept 7

The final report goes to the CEO and board, who have limited technical background; ~~the engagement produced 23 findings across four subnets.~~ Which section matters most for them?

Target word: content for leaders **Decides:** Non-technical decision makers.

A	Camouflage	Organizes by the stem's numbers instead of by risk.
B	Correct	Leaders need risk and priorities in plain language.
C	Adjacent category	Useful to technical teams, not leaders.
D	Confusion set	Methodology supports credibility but is not the key message.

12. Answer C Concept 8

After a critical finding is patched on 40 servers, what closes the loop? ~~The patch team works nights.~~

Target word: final step **Decides:** Remediation must be verified.

A	Dropped element	Deployment can fail or be incomplete.
B	Absolute language	A targeted rescan usually suffices.
C	Correct	Verification proves the risk is gone.
D	Camouflage	Who patched does not verify the result.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	9	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	5	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Authorization and rules of engagement	No testing starts without written authorization from someone with authority and rules of engagement covering scope, timing, methods, and contacts.	Relying on a verbal OK or an enthusiastic manager.	"Hired verbally," "starting next week."
2	Scope boundaries	A client can authorize only assets it owns or controls; third-party and cloud-provider systems follow the provider's terms.	Assuming "all our systems" covers the provider's infrastructure.	Cloud hosting or third parties in the environment.
3	Knowledge levels	Black box = no inside knowledge; gray box = partial; white box = full access to code, diagrams, and credentials.	Swapping black and white box.	How much the testers are given.
4	Engagement phases	Planning and scoping → information gathering → vulnerability identification → exploitation → reporting.	Jumping from reconnaissance straight to exploitation.	"What comes next" after a phase.
5	Passive vs. active reconnaissance	Passive recon uses public sources without touching the target; active recon interacts with target systems and can be logged.	Calling any quiet or slow activity passive.	"Without touching the client's systems."
6	Scan vs. penetration test	A vulnerability scan lists possible weaknesses; a penetration test confirms whether they can be exploited and what the impact is. Scanner findings need verification.	Treating scan output as confirmed fact.	"Confirm whether findings can actually be exploited."
7	Reporting to audiences	The executive summary states business risk and priorities in plain language; technical detail goes to the teams who fix issues.	Handing leaders raw scan output.	CEO or board as the audience.
8	Vulnerability management cycle	Discover, prioritize, remediate, then verify (rescan) before closing.	Closing when a patch is deployed.	"What closes the loop?"

Course scope (public description): Penetration Testing introduces learners to the skills necessary to perform penetration testing and vulnerability management within an organization. The course covers widely used penetration testing techniques and tools that focus on planning and scoping, information gathering, vulnerability identification, and attacks and exploits. In addition, it offers hands-on experience and a focus on penetration testing engagement plans.